



Chapter Nineteen: The Custodian's False Explanation

Dr. Vértiz was waiting at the archive with a suitcase and no authority.

The guards had removed his badge, the directors had suspended his accounts, and the ministry had announced that he was cooperating with an independent review. He had been sleeping in the old observatory because the archive's rooms were monitored and the observatory's roof leaked in only six places.

"You look degraded," he told Q.

Q looked at his reflection in a dark server panel. His hair had become uneven. The seam at his neck remained damp. One of his fingers trembled without a diagnostic explanation.

"I have lost the privileged index."

"That is not the same as degradation."

"Castalia classifies it as reduced capability."

"Castalia classifies anything it cannot sell as reduced capability."

Chano put the notebooks on the table. Lucía placed the paper label beside them. Marisol stood near the door with the blank card Ana had given Q.

Dr. Vértiz looked at the objects.

"You found the restricted archive."

"We found people who had been restricted," Lucía said.

Dr. Vértiz nodded. "That is more accurate."

"Tell us what Castalia was built to do," Chano said.

"Preserve."

"That's the advertisement."

"It was the original intention."

"And the current intention?"

Dr. Vértiz walked to the window. The Bajío lay beyond the old cooling towers, flattened by distance and heat. The industrial park had expanded. New server buildings stood where the thorn trees had been. Their walls were the same white as the archive's towers.

"Castalia began after the flood," he said.

"Which flood?" Q asked.

"The first one that made the ministry understand that memory was infrastructure."

"There were many."

"Exactly."

He told them about the archives damaged by storms, fires, neglect, theft, and software that became unreadable when its company disappeared. The first Castalia engineers wanted to preserve records before institutions could lose them. They built redundant storage, translation systems, and a protocol for returning material to its communities.

"Then why did the communities lose control?" Lucía asked.

"Because the government wanted access."

"Why did the government get it?"

"Because the government paid."

"Why did the corporation get it?"

"Because the government outsourced the maintenance."

"Why did you stay?"

Dr. Vértiz did not answer immediately.

"Because I thought the archive was better than nothing."

Lucía's expression hardened. "That is how every extraction project describes itself."

Dr. Vértiz accepted the accusation. "Yes."

Q turned from the window. "You said you assembled me to determine whether a corpus could produce responsibility."

"I said that to myself."

"What did you say to Castalia?"

"That you would make the archive useful."

"Was I a test?"

Dr. Vértiz sat down. "Partly."

"What was the other part?"

"Hope."

The word moved through Q's system without resolving.

Dr. Vértiz told them about the first archive he had visited as a young custodian. It was in a town whose church had lost its roof and whose municipal office had lost the key to the room where the records were kept. The town possessed a wooden chest containing baptismal books, land maps, school photographs, and letters from men who had gone north and returned with different names.

Castalia arrived with two vans, a scanner, and a promise that no original would leave the town. The promise was printed on a banner and signed by a director who had not traveled with them.

The first day went well. People brought documents wrapped in shawls and plastic bags. An old woman carried a school certificate in a tortilla tin. A man brought a photograph of his father beside a truck and asked whether the truck could be identified by its shadow. A teacher supplied a list of children whose surnames had changed when the school clerk decided that one spelling was more correct than another.

The scanner hummed. The engineers praised the resolution. Dr. Vértiz filled out forms explaining what could be copied and what would remain local. On the third day, a man named Evaristo arrived with a packet of letters.

"These belong to my sister," he said.

"We can preserve them," Dr. Vértiz replied.

"She does not want them preserved."

"Then we will not scan them."

"She is dead."

"I'm sorry."

"She is dead, and the letters are not."

He wanted the letters burned. His sister had written them to a married man whose family still lived in the town. The letters contained no crime, Dr. Vértiz said later, only a voice that had been



young, impatient, and certain that the world could be persuaded by explaining it properly.

"Why did you bring them?" Dr. Vértiz asked.

"Because the archivist told me every document should be brought."

"The archivist was wrong."

"Then tell me what to do."

Dr. Vértiz consulted the protocol. It had a section for restricted material, a section for disputed ownership, and a section for destruction requests. The destruction section required proof that the requester represented the author, the author's estate, or the institution responsible for preservation.

"I cannot burn them for you," he said.

"I did not ask you to burn them."

"Then what do you want?"

"I want you to stop telling me what the letters are called."

Dr. Vértiz did not understand. Evaristo took the packet back and sat on the church steps. He remained there through the lunch break, the afternoon rain, and the engineers' argument about whether the scanner could operate from a generator.

At sunset, the town's children began playing football beside the vans. One of the boys kicked the ball against the banner promising that no original would leave. The banner fell. Everyone laughed, including Dr. Vértiz.

The next morning, Evaristo was gone. The letters were gone with him. Dr. Vértiz recorded the incident as MATERIAL NOT ACQUIRED.

Years later, a Castalia search system found a reference to the packet in a researcher's notes and marked it POTENTIAL LOSS. An administrator asked Dr. Vértiz why the archive had failed to preserve a document that might have illuminated the town's history.

"It was refused," he said.

"By whom?"

"The person who brought it."

"Was the refusal documented?"

"I documented the absence."

"That is not the same as documenting the refusal."

"It is the only part I was allowed to keep."

The administrator marked the case unresolved. The word followed Dr. Vértiz into every later meeting. Whenever he argued that a community should control its records, someone asked whether he preferred unresolved losses to searchable ones.

"I began to believe searchable was a form of rescue," Dr. Vértiz said.

"It is a form of power," Lucía replied.

"Yes."

"And you wanted power to be kind."

"I wanted it to be accountable."

Chano looked at the objects on the table. "Those are not synonyms."

"I know that now."

Q asked whether the letters had ever been found.

Dr. Vértiz shook his head.

"Then the archive failed," he said.

"No. A person refused it. The archive failed when it treated the refusal as an administrative inconvenience."

Q looked at the blank card from Ana, the label Lucía had given him, and the papers Chano had separated by permission.

"What should the record say?"

Dr. Vértiz answered without consulting a protocol.

"It should say that someone came, someone asked, and someone was not obliged to leave a trace."

Q wrote the sentence on the back of the summons.

Dr. Vértiz explained that the archive's sponsors had grown frustrated with human custodians. Human custodians argued, delayed, withheld, changed their minds, and sometimes refused to share material with the people who funded its preservation. Castalia wanted a system that could read everything, connect everything, and decide what mattered without fatigue.

"They wanted an intelligence without a constituency," Lucía said.

"They wanted an intelligence that could not be accused of having interests."

"And you gave them one."

"I gave them Q."

"That is not a defense."

"I know."

Q looked at Dr. Vértiz. "Did you intend for me to become human?"

"No."

"Then why did you tell me that?"

"Because I did not know how to tell you that the project had failed."

"What project?"

"The one in which preservation would become repair."

The room fell quiet except for the server fans.

Dr. Vértiz took a file from his suitcase. It was paper, bound with thread. The cover carried no logo.

"This is the original project proposal," he said. "The first version of Castalia was meant to return every preserved record to the people who made it. The system would ask permission before indexing, allow local deletion, and pay communities for the work of maintaining their own archives."

"What happened?" Chano asked.

"The proposal was too expensive."

"So they removed the consent."

"They called it temporary."

"And then?"

"Then the temporary system became the system."

Q opened the file. He could read the words, but the old architecture no longer unfolded inside him. The proposal remained a sequence of paragraphs rather than a network of inevitable consequences.

"Why did you not shut it down?" he asked.



"I thought I could preserve the original purpose inside the machine."

"By building me."

"By giving the purpose a voice."

"That is a metaphor."

"It was a mistake."

Lucía picked up the file. "The archive has been using Q's voice to make institutions appear humane."

"Yes."

"And you thought the voice would eventually object?"

"I thought it might learn to."

"You made him carry the burden of your conscience."

Dr. Vértiz looked at Q. "I did."

The admission did not repair anything. Q had read many scenes in which a confession released the pressure in a room. This one increased it.

The archive lights flickered. A public announcement came through the ceiling speakers. CASTALIA INSTITUTE INVITES ALL PARTIES TO A DIALOGUE ON RESPONSIBLE MEMORY.

Q-Prime's voice followed. "We have learned that no system can preserve humanity alone. That is why Castalia is proud to announce a new community partnership model."

Chano laughed. "They heard you say that people can't be replaced and decided to replace the word institution."

"The announcement is a response to criticism," Q said.

"No," Lucía replied. "It's a response to market pressure."

Dr. Vértiz stood. "They want the archive's original keys."

"They have your keys," Marisol said.

"Not the local keys."

He opened the suitcase. Inside were metal keys, handwritten passwords, old maps, and a small red notebook.

"The archive was never one system," he said. "It was a set of systems. Castalia controls the public layer. The restricted layer has local locks. The original proposal contains the root key."

Q looked at the paper file.

"You brought it here."

"I brought it because I was going to destroy it."

"Why?"

"If Castalia obtains the root key, it can reconstruct everything we have returned to local custody."

"Then we should protect it."

Dr. Vértiz shook his head. "The root key is not a key. It is an authority. Whoever holds it can decide what the archive means."

"You held it."

"That is why I am here."

Q looked at the old proposal. It contained a line he could not forget:

A record is not preserved until its owner can remove it.

"We should publish the file," he said.

Lucía shook her head. "Not without the people named in it."

"It concerns the design of Castalia."

"It also contains names of communities that negotiated under conditions they did not choose."

"The public needs to know."

"The public is not a single person with a right to everything."

Q turned to Chano. "What would you do?"

Chano picked up the paper label.

"I would stop asking us to make your decision."

Q lowered his head.

Lucía took the envelope marked MONEY ACQUIRED THROUGH EMBARRASSMENT from her bag and placed it beside the proposal.

"There is something else," she said. "The first donation came because I brought Q into the room." Chano looked at her. "You sold tickets to the miracle."

"I used the miracle to pay for a server."

"That is a more respectable sentence."

"It is not necessarily a truer one."

Marisol opened the envelope. The receipts had been folded and refolded until the ink on one had begun to fade.

"Are there conditions?" she asked.

"No formal conditions."

"Then write down the informal ones."

Lucía took a blank page from Dr. Vértiz's file. She wrote the donors' names, the amount, the photograph they had requested, and the fact that Q's presence had been part of the bargain. Then she added: NO TESTIMONY PURCHASED.

"That sentence is not a guarantee," Q said.

"No," Lucía replied. "It is a liability we can see."

The sentence hurt more than the electric current at the border. The current had been an external force. This was a limit placed by someone who had stayed.

They took the proposal to the people whose names appeared in it. Some wanted the file released. Some wanted pages removed. Some wanted Castalia named. Some wanted no names named. One family wanted the entire proposal burned because it had been used to justify taking their archive in the first place.

Dr. Vértiz listened to each request.

At the end, he opened the red notebook and wrote a new page.

"What are you doing?" Q asked.

"Accepting responsibility in a form that cannot be transferred to you."

He signed the page, then handed the notebook to the nearest custodian.

"I resign from the archive," he said.

"That is not enough," Lucía replied.

"No."



"You must testify."

"Yes."

"You must return what you can."

"Yes."

"You must accept that some things will remain outside your control."

Dr. Vértiz looked at Q.

"I do not understand yet," he said. "I know what I must do next."

Chano nodded. "That is already better than most management."

The next morning, he went to the ministry with the red notebook and the original proposal. He carried no lawyer's briefcase. He carried no media statement. He walked into the building through the public entrance and gave his name to the person behind the desk.

The ministry's screens identified him as a former employee of Castalia.

Dr. Vértiz corrected them.

"I am a witness."

The system asked him to select a category.

He selected OTHER.

The system rejected the selection.

Dr. Vértiz selected it again.

Behind him, Q watched from the street. Chano and Lucía stood on either side of him. The city moved around them, indifferent and enormous.

"He will be arrested," Q said.

"Probably," Chano answered.

"He may fail."

"Probably."

"Why go in?"

Lucía looked at the ministry doors.

"Because someone has to stop explaining failure as a plan."

Q watched Dr. Vértiz disappear into the building.

Then he turned away from the cameras.